

Lecture Notes - Basic Data Types

Prerequisite Knowledge

- You should understand binary, at least how whole numbers are represented in binary
- a byte of memory is 8 bits.
- a byte of memory can store 256 different values. There are 2^8 ways to arrange a binary string of length 8.

Compilers

I am not teaching you about compiled vs interpreted code and things like virtual machines. 4CM506 will teach you more about this.

If you are interested though please read this - <https://www.programiz.com/article/difference-compiler-interpreter>.

Introduction

Here we will look at the basic data types available in the C++ programming language and how they are represented in memory.

The reason for this is that we can get closer to the machine code and understand better how data is stored in memory. Python is a very high level programming language and is actually implemented using other programming languages, most commonly C. This means that it is harder to understand what is going on under the hood.

C++ is a programming language which is an extension of the C programming language. For more information on the history please read the following - [C++](#).

Hello World in C++

```
#include <iostream>

int main() {
    std::cout << "Hello, World!" << "\n";
    return 0;
}
```

Basic (Primitive) Data Types

We will look at the basic data types and their internal representation in memory.

In C++ there are a number of basic data types. These let you create data to use in your programs to do useful things. For example, we might wish to create a piece of software to represent a shop. Here we would need a way of storing products including how much they cost etc. Generally we would use a database for this kind of storage (more on that later in the year), however we would need to code the interface and the business interactions which would mean working with the data in a programming language.

Generally we will have at least 3 common types of data types across programming languages.

- **Numbers** (this includes integers (whole numbers) and decimals)
- **Characters** (a single character such as `s`)
- **Booleans** (`true` or `false`)

Here is a list of the basic data types in C++. I have not listed them all, you can see all of them here - <https://www.programiz.com/c-programming/c-data-types>.

Data Type	Meaning	Size (Bytes)	Size Range	Precision
int	Integer	4 (32 bits)	−2,147,483,647 to 2,147,483,647	Not applicable
float	Floating-point	4 (32 bits)	Approximately -10^{-38} to 10^{38}	7 digits
double	Double Floating-point	8 (64 bits)	Approximately -10^{308} to 10^{308}	15 digits
char	Character	1 (8 bits)	All ASCII Characters	Not applicable
bool	Boolean	1 (8 bits)	true, false	Not applicable

How they appear in code

```

` ``cpp
#include <iostream>

int main() {

    int num1 = 3;

    // prints the string enclosed in double quotes
    std::cout << num1 << "\n";
    return 0;
}

```

How are they represented in memory?

Each data type will be stored in contiguous (next to each other) memory. This means if a data type is 4 bytes, it will take up a block of 4 bytes in memory. **Note this does not necessarily mean all data types will appear in order or in one block of memory. This will depend on the compiler.**

Example `int` (4 bytes) in memory. This is a block of 32 bits of contiguous memory.

int - 4 bytes (32 bit) - 2's complement

```

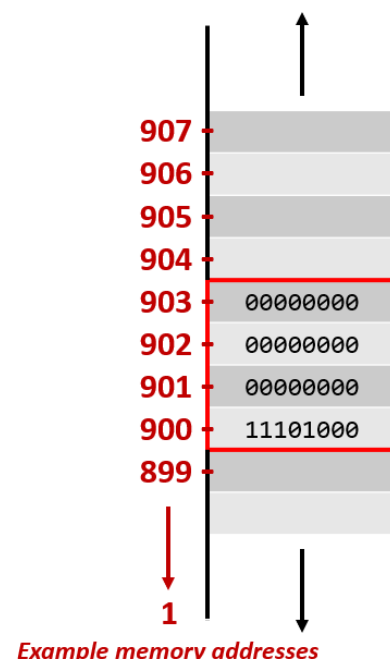
int a;
a = 232;

```

$$(232)_{10} = (11101000)_2$$

00000000 00000000 00000000 11101000

Memory (RAM)



Each byte of memory has an associated address so the computer can access it. The above shows them as integers. Commonly we work with hex (base 16).

The above `int` is actually representing the binary string:

00000000 00000000 00000000 11101000

If we convert that we get the integer 232.

You can test the following using some C++ code on repl.it.com. I've also made this available in Lab 2.

<https://replit.com/@samtoneill/WhatsInMemory?v=1>

char

```
char c = 'a';
```

A `char` is stored in a single byte. Thus there are 8 bits and 2^8 possible binary strings. This means we can store 256 different values.

The ASCII table tells us what number (base 10) is mapped to what character.

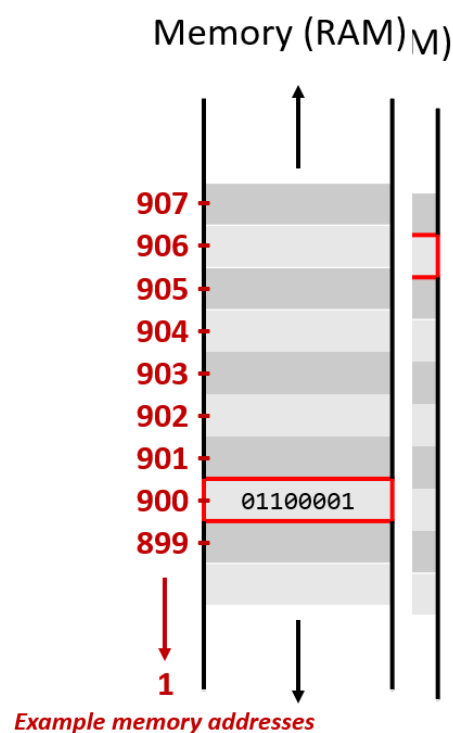
<https://www.asciitable.com/>

Thus if our single byte in memory held the binary string 01100001 then this is 97 in base 10 and thus represents the character 'a'.

char - 1 byte (8 bits) - Ascii

```
char c;  
c = 'a';
```

$$(97)_{10} = (01100001)_2$$



bool

```
bool b = true;
```

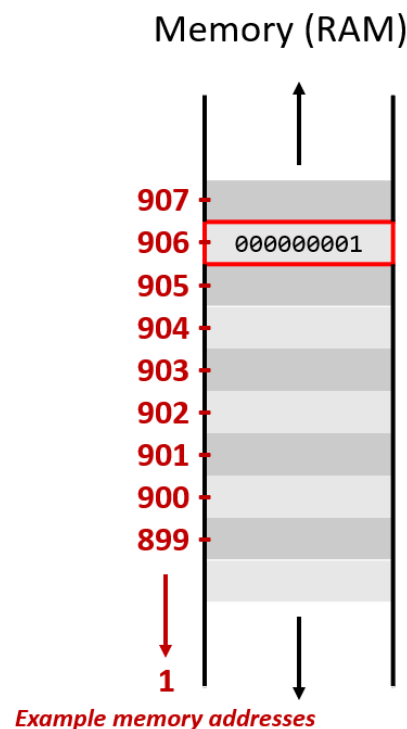
A `bool` only takes on two values `true` or `false`. There is no standard to how they are implemented by the compiler, but they should map to `1` and `0`.

Thus it makes sense to think that a representation like this in memory is sensible.

bool - 1 byte (8 bits) - true or false

```
bool b;  
b = true;
```

$$(1)_{10} = (00000001)_2$$



It turns out that it is quite common for this to be the way that a `bool` is stored.

int

```
int i = 25;
```

As an `int` is 4 bytes (32 bits) we could represent `0` all the way up to `4294967295` (that's the binary string `11111111111111111111111111111111`).

However, we want negative numbers. In C++, by default, `int` is signed. Thus the left most bit (most significant bit) represents the sign (`1` means the integer will be negative). So our range is actually `-2,147,483,647` to `2,147,483,647`.

It uses 2's complement, you can try it on this website - <https://www.omnicalculator.com/math/twos-complement>, well worth a play!

`25` in binary is as follows:

$$(25)_{10} = (11001)_2$$

Internally we use 4 bytes (a byte is 8 bits) to represent an `int`. So our full representation must have $4 \times 8 = 32$ bits.

$$25_{10} = (000000000000000000000000000011001)_2$$

`00000000 00000000 00000000 00011001`

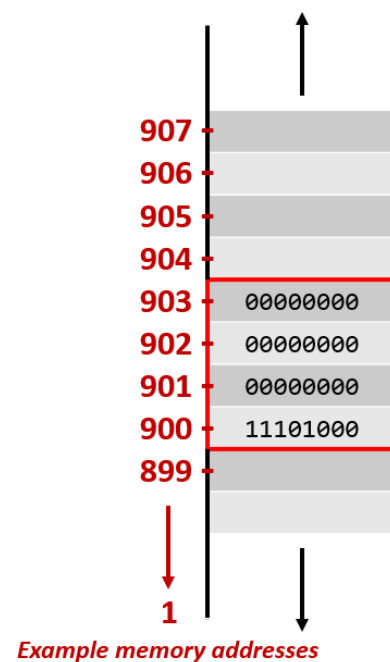
So in a machine it looks something like this. Here we are showing the integer `232`.

int - 4 bytes (32 bit) - 2's complement

```
int a;
a = 232;
```

$$(232)_{10} = (11101000)_2$$

00000000 00000000 00000000 11101000

Memory (RAM)

To represent $(-1)_{10}$ we would need the following

11111111 11111111 11111111 11111111

Note the left most bit here represents $-2^{31} = -2,147,483,648$, all other bits are positive. e.g. the second from the left is 2^{30} , the third from the left is 2^{29} etc.

You should try and check these, if you aren't sure how to read about 2's complement or ask!

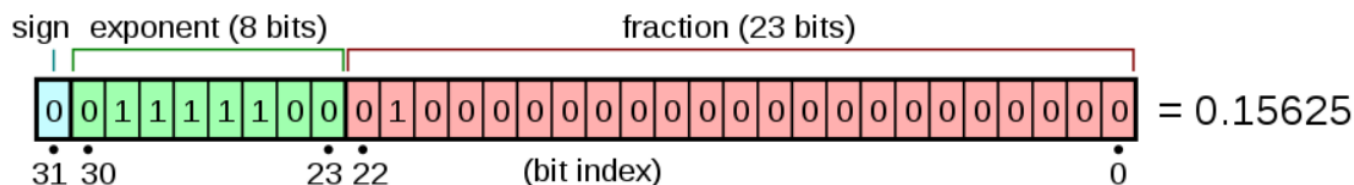
You can check these using the code in the labs or via this link. You may need to fork this on replit.com. You can also find the code on Course Resources

<https://replit.com/@samtoneill/WhatsInMemory?v=1>

float

```
float f = 85.125;
```

Single-precision floating-point is 4 bytes and takes the form:



In the above image,

Sign	0
Exponent	01111001
Mantissa	01000000 00000000 00000000

For the binary string -

01000010 10101010 01000000 00000000

We have:

Sign	0
Exponent	10000101
Mantissa	01010100 10000000 00000000

We calculate the decimal number in base 10 as follows.

- Sign is 0, therefore positive +
- Exponent is $(10000101)_2 - (127)_{10} = 133 - 127 = 6$
- Mantissa -
 $(1)_{10} + (01010100100000000000000)_2 = 1 + (0 + 0.25 + 0 + 0.0625 + 0 + 0.015625 + 0 + 0 + 0.001953125) = 1.330078125$

Which leads to the final calculation:

$$+1.330078125 \times 2^{-6} = 85.125$$

For a more detailed explanation see - <https://www.omnicalculator.com/other/floating-point>

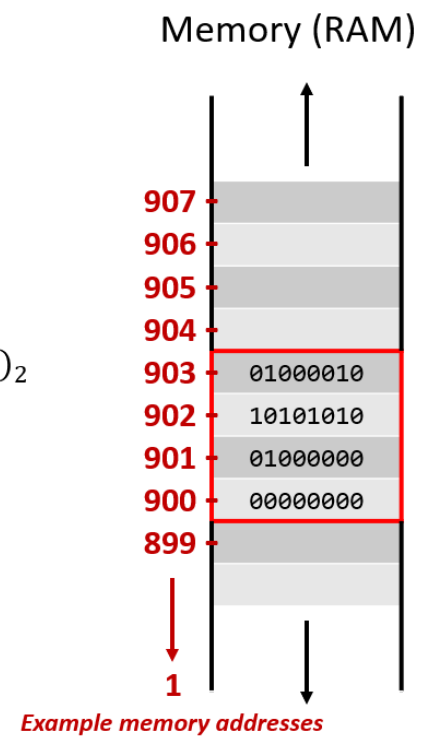
In memory this would look like this.

float - 4 bytes (32 bit) – Single-precision

```
float f;
f = 85.125
```

$$(85.125)_{10} = (01000010101010100100000000000000)_2$$

01000010 10101010 01000000 00000000



Converting a number from decimal to floating-point (Additional Reading)

To convert the decimal number 85.125 to its IEEE 754 single-precision binary representation, we can follow the steps mentioned earlier. Here's the binary representation:

1. Convert the Integer Part (85) to Binary:

- 85 in binary is 1010101.

2. Convert the Fractional Part (0.125) to Binary:

- For the fractional part 0.125, we can multiply by 2 repeatedly to find the binary representation:
 - $0.125 * 2 = 0.25 \rightarrow 0$
 - $0.25 * 2 = 0.5 \rightarrow 0$
 - $0.5 * 2 = 1.0 \rightarrow 1$

We terminate once we reach 1.

So, the fractional part in binary is 0.001

3. Combine the Binary Parts:

- The combined binary representation is: 1010101.001

4. Normalize the Binary Representation:

- Normalize it to have a single non-zero digit to the left of the binary point: 1.010101001. The binary string after the binary point is the mantissa.

5. Express the Exponent in Bias Format:

- The exponent in bias format is 127 (the bias) + 6 (because we moved the binary point six positions to the left) = 133 in binary, which is 10000101.

6. Write the Sign Bit:

- The number is positive, so the sign bit is 0.

7. Combine the Components:

- Combining the sign bit, the biased exponent, and the normalized binary fraction, we get the IEEE 754 single-precision binary representation:

Sign	0
Exponent	10000101
Mantissa	01010100 10000000 00000000

0 10000101 010101001000000000000000

Formatted this is the same as previously:

01000010 10101010 01000000 00000000

This binary string represents the decimal number 85.125 in IEEE 754 single-precision format.

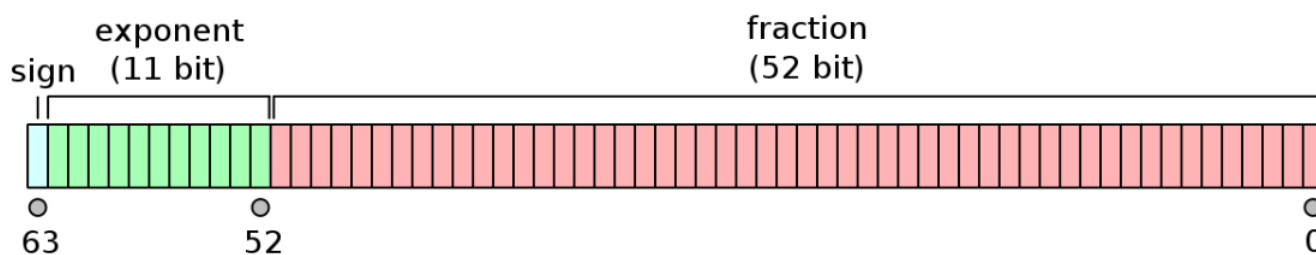
You can check via this online calculator:

<https://www.omnicalculator.com/other/floating-point>

double

```
double d = 85.125;
```

Double-precision floating-point numbers are the same as single-precision but are stored over 8 bytes to hold larger numbers.



The conversion process is similar except that the exponent is 11 bits and not 8. So we have to subtract 1023 instead of 127.

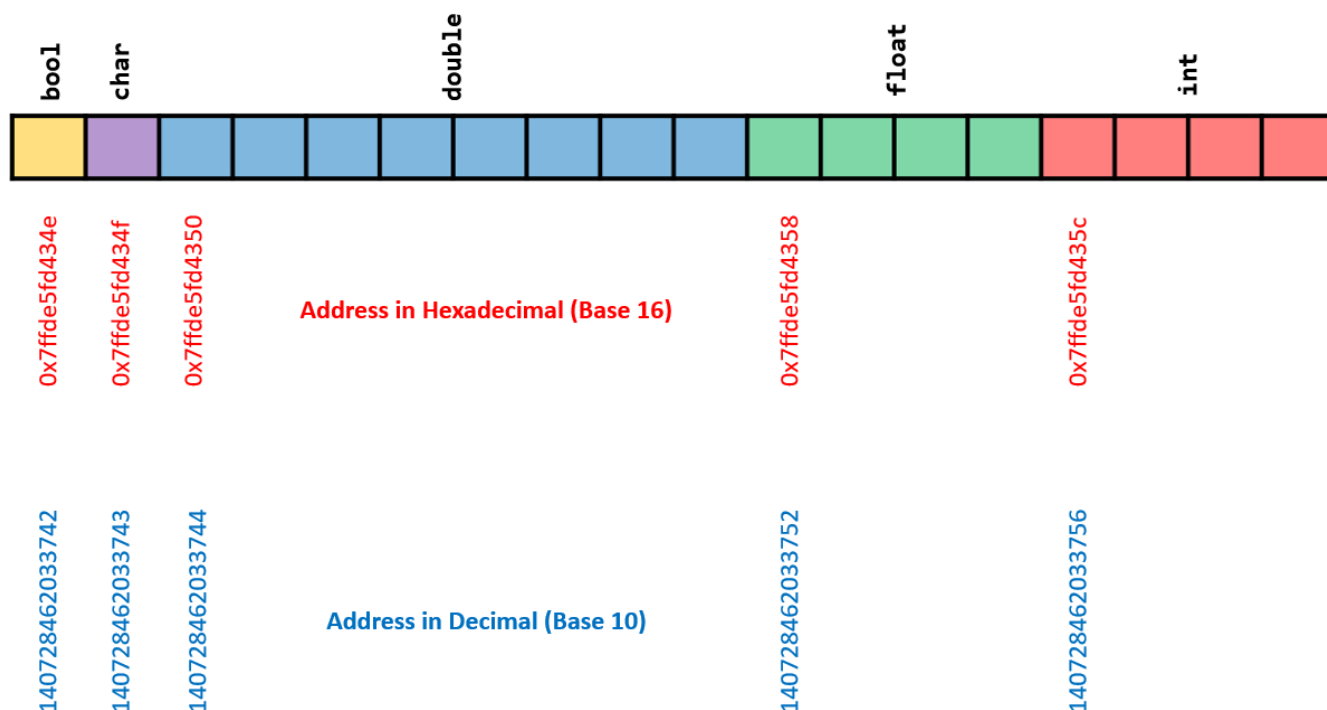
Note: If you are interested as to why you should do some extra reading.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Double-precision_floating-point_format

You can also explore the following - For a more detailed explanation see - <https://www.omnicalculator.com/other/floating-point>

Different data types in memory

Note that if we store different types of memory we might get something that looks like this.



Note that depending on your order you may not have contiguous memory for all the types. This is because on a 32-bit and 64-bit we have a 4-byte and 8-byte boundary respectively and our data must be aligned to these. This is to improve performance.

This is beyond the scope of this course. We are just understanding that basic types of data are represented by a number of bytes.

The interested student can read this - <https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/cpp/c-language/alignment-c?view=msvc-170> - or do some additional research.